

Catch up: Iran denies talks start Monday; Japan and America prop up the yen



Photograph: AFP

Iran's foreign ministry denied that it is holding talks with America, despite Donald Trump's insistence that negotiations were starting on Monday. Mr Trump had already called off further attacks, partially in response to pleas from America's regional partners including the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia. Iran said that it was in discussions with Oman over the Strait of Hormuz.

Scott Bessent, America's treasury secretary, said that America "will not hesitate" to prop up **the yen** and confirmed that it had done so last week. Katayama Satsuki, his Japanese counterpart, said that it had been a "joint intervention", and that the countries were ready to do more. Having traded at ¥163 to the dollar on Thursday, the yen has strengthened to ¥155.

Myanmar's armed forces released photos of a meeting between **Aung San Suu Kyi**, a detained former leader, and a representative of the Red Cross. It said the meeting took place on Monday. In 2021 a military coup removed Ms Suu Kyi's elected civilian government and imprisoned her. She **had not been seen** by anyone unaffiliated with the regime since her show trial ended in 2022.

Wildfires eased across parts of western **Europe**. In southwestern France, 200,000 people who had been evacuated from their homes

were allowed to return. Major [fires](#) in Spain are no longer advancing. The most dangerous front has shifted to Greece, where gale-force winds fanned blazes over the weekend. Two helicopters collided there while fighting the fires, killing two crew members.

The death toll from a [surge of migrants](#) into the Spanish exclave of **Ceuta** last week reached at least 72. More than 50,000 people crossed the border, but Spain said some 48,000 returned to Morocco within 48 hours. Morocco's interior ministry blamed misinformation on social media for the events. The European Union will hold an emergency meeting on Tuesday to discuss the crisis.

Volodymyr Zelensky, **Ukraine's** president, said his country's forces carried out strikes deep inside **Russia**, hitting a big oil refinery and an airfield. Russia said it had hit two Ukrainian ports and two ships in the Black Sea. With the frontline largely static, both sides have intensified [attacks](#) on cities and energy infrastructure. Meanwhile at least three people were killed in Moscow on Saturday by a homemade bomb.

UEFA threatened to sue FIFA and Gianni Infantino, its boss, over plans to sell shares in a corporate entity that would consolidate the commercial operations of football's global organising body. The European affiliate demanded that all documents related to [the scheme](#), which would have raised more than \$4bn, be preserved. Mr Infantino backed down from the idea on Friday after widespread outcry in the footballing world.

Figure of the day: 36%, Europe's share of global heat deaths, despite having just 10% of the world's population. [Read about how the geopolitics of air-conditioning](#) plays a role.

Deal or no deal?



Photograph: ABEDIN TAHERKENAREH/EPA/Shutterstock

He did it again. Donald Trump's administration spent much of last week hinting that America was prepared to launch a massive attack on Iran. But on Saturday the president announced that he had shelved the assault because—why else?—he was on the precipice of an agreement with Iran. Later he said that new talks to end the war would start on Monday. This [cycle of threat and retreat](#) has become routine over the past few months. Mr Trump had plenty of reasons not to escalate. America's allies in the Gulf feared Iran would hit them hard. Pentagon planners fret about dwindling supplies of air-defence interceptors.

But it is unclear what deal he claims to be close to. The previous agreement, the so-called memorandum of understanding signed in June, collapsed last month after Iran refused to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Diplomats from Oman have tried to mediate a compromise in which regional countries would establish a consortium to control the strait. But Iran rejected the idea. The cycle continues.

A status check for summer travel



Photograph: Getty Images

Three travel companies, Marriott, Booking Holdings and Airbnb, all report earnings this week. Their results will help investors assess a summer-holiday season unusually affected by global events. Strong demand from World Cup fans in North America was good news for hoteliers. Dampened Middle East sales due to America's and Israel's war with Iran was not.

If the second-quarter earnings posted last week by Hilton, a competitor, are anything to go by, the upcoming crop of results will be decidedly mixed. Hilton beat Wall Street expectations, in large part due to strong demand from football fanatics. Yet revenues per available room, a key industry metric, in the Middle East were lacklustre. They were in China, too, chiefly because of restrictions on outbound group tours—most notably to Japan, following a series of [diplomatic spats](#) over Taiwan. Such factors may explain why, despite rising revenue, Hilton's stock fell more than 3% on the results. There's no checking out from geopolitics.

Attempts to take over easyJet hit turbulence



Photograph: Getty Images

A battle over easyJet may soon be concluded. The initial takeover bid from Castlelake, an American investment firm, was £5.60 (\$7.55) a share—several overtures later, easyJet’s board finally accepted a boosted offer of £6.90. But a couple of days later Apollo, another American investor, swooped in with a bid of £7.15 a share, which the board then accepted instead.

Under British takeover rules, Castlelake must raise its bid by Monday or take off. Who wins will be consequential for the airline. Castlelake may want the company to be **broken up**: easyJet’s holiday business, current fleet and order book for new planes are all significant assets. But Apollo has pledged to stick with the company’s current strategy of upgrading its planes and expanding its holiday packages. This, it reckons, could generate £1bn in pre-tax profits in the medium term—meaning it will take Apollo a little while to recoup the total £5.7bn it is currently offering.

What next for the boss of the beautiful game?



Photograph: AFP

Just a fortnight ago, Gianni Infantino—the head of FIFA, football’s governing body, —handed [Spain](#) the World Cup trophy in a jubilant mood. The tournament had been contentious, but it also raked in a record-breaking \$15bn. Yet Mr Infantino wanted more. Last week he unveiled a plan to sell stakes in a new entity, valued at \$20bn, to help run the World Cup and unlock “previously uncaptured commercial value”.

This proved to be an own goal. Pushback was fierce, led by football associations across Europe, Asia and the Americas who were incensed by both the concept and the lack of consultation. The furore forced FIFA to withdraw the plan on Friday. But the fallout will probably last longer: some of the organisation’s members hope to dismiss Mr Infantino in the coming weeks (he faces re-election in 2027) and are calling for governance reforms. The organisation, though, is [no stranger to scandals](#). Mr Infantino may get a red card, but that won’t necessarily change the game.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: What happens on the Orient Express in the title of the Agatha Christie novel?

*Better to doubt methodically than
to think capriciously.*

Stanley Baldwin